

Swimming for Arthritis: The Complete Guide to Aquatic Exercise

Complete UK guide to swimming for arthritis. Discover benefits, find local hydrotherapy pools, learn safe strokes and get started with aquatic exercise for joint pain.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-23 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk



*Person swimming gentle laps in a warm indoor pool for arthritis therapy
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Swimming and aquatic exercise are consistently ranked among the most effective forms of physical activity for people living with arthritis. The unique properties of water

— buoyancy, warmth, resistance and hydrostatic pressure — create an ideal environment for gentle yet effective exercise that strengthens muscles, improves flexibility and reduces pain without placing excessive stress on already sensitive joints. In the UK, millions of people have access to public swimming pools and leisure centres, making aquatic exercise one of the most accessible forms of arthritis-friendly activity. This comprehensive guide covers everything you need to know about swimming for arthritis in the UK, from the science behind its benefits to practical advice on getting started.

Why Water Exercise Is So Effective for Arthritis

Buoyancy Reduces Joint Load

When you stand in water up to your waist, your body weight is reduced by approximately 50%. In chest-deep water, the reduction is around 70–80%, and in neck-deep water, you bear only about 10% of your body weight. This dramatic reduction in gravitational loading means that movements which might be painful or impossible on land — such as walking, bending or lifting your legs — become comfortable and achievable in water. For people with knee or hip osteoarthritis, this buoyancy effect is particularly valuable, as it allows strengthening exercises to be performed without the joint compression that occurs during land-based activities.

Warm Water Eases Stiffness

Most UK hydrotherapy pools are maintained at temperatures between 33°C and 36°C — significantly warmer than standard swimming pools (which are typically 26–28°C). This warmth increases blood flow to muscles and joints, promotes relaxation of tight tissues, and can reduce pain perception. Even standard-temperature pools offer benefits compared to cold outdoor environments. The combination of warmth and movement helps to increase the elasticity of connective tissues, making stretches more effective and reducing the risk of injury.

Water Resistance Builds Strength

Water provides natural resistance in all directions — roughly 12 times greater than air. This means that every movement you make in water is a strengthening exercise. Unlike weights, water resistance is accommodating: the harder you push, the more resistance you encounter, but if you move slowly, the resistance decreases. This self-adjusting nature makes water

exercise inherently safe for arthritis patients, as you naturally limit the force on your joints to a comfortable level.

Hydrostatic Pressure Reduces Swelling

The pressure exerted by water on the submerged body helps to reduce joint and tissue swelling. This hydrostatic pressure also improves circulation and can help with the removal of inflammatory by-products from joint tissues. Research published in the *Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews* confirms that aquatic exercise produces clinically meaningful improvements in pain, function and quality of life for both osteoarthritis and rheumatoid arthritis.

Best Swimming Strokes for Arthritis



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Backstroke

Generally considered the most arthritis-friendly stroke. Backstroke keeps the spine in a neutral position, doesn't require neck rotation (unlike front crawl), and uses a symmetrical arm movement that is gentle on the shoulders. The flutter kick strengthens hip and knee muscles without extreme bending. If you're new to backstroke, start with a float or kickboard under your arms for support.

Breaststroke (with Modifications)

Breaststroke can be helpful for hip arthritis as the frog kick gently opens the hip joints. However, the traditional breaststroke kick can aggravate knee problems, particularly if you have patellofemoral issues. A modified version with a narrower kick and head kept in a more neutral position (not lifted high) can reduce strain. Speak to a swimming instructor about modifications suited to your condition.

Front Crawl (Freestyle)

An excellent cardiovascular workout that strengthens shoulders, arms and core. The constant rotation may aggravate shoulder arthritis in some people, so start with short distances and monitor your response. Use bilateral breathing (breathing on both sides) to maintain symmetry and reduce neck strain. Swim fins can take pressure off the upper body by providing extra propulsion from the legs.

Water Walking and Jogging

If swimming strokes feel too demanding, simply walking or jogging in chest-deep water provides an excellent workout. The water resistance builds leg strength and the buoyancy protects your joints. Walking forwards, backwards and sideways targets different muscle groups. This is often the best starting point for people new to aquatic exercise or those with severe joint limitations.

Finding the Right Pool in the UK

Hydrotherapy Pools

Hydrotherapy pools offer the warmest water temperatures and are specifically designed for therapeutic exercise. In the UK, you can access hydrotherapy through:

- NHS referral — Your GP or physiotherapist can refer you for hydrotherapy sessions at NHS hospitals and rehabilitation centres. These are typically supervised by chartered physiotherapists. Waiting times vary by area

- Private physiotherapy clinics — Many offer hydrotherapy sessions for a fee, usually £30–£60 per session
- Charitable organisations — Some local arthritis support groups run hydrotherapy sessions at subsidised rates

Local Authority Pools

Most UK towns and cities have public leisure centres with swimming pools. Many offer:

- Quieter swim sessions — Often mornings or early afternoons when lanes are less crowded
- Over-50s sessions — Dedicated times for older adults
- Disability swimming sessions — Pools may provide hoists, accessible changing rooms and additional staff support
- Aqua-aerobics classes — Group exercise in the pool, often with modifications for different ability levels
- Concession pricing — Reduced rates for people with disabilities, over-60s and those on benefits

Contact your local council or search the Swim England website (swimming.org) to find pools and session times near you. Many councils issue leisure cards that provide discounted access.

Getting Started: A Beginner's Plan



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Week 1–2: Water Walking

Start with 10–15 minutes of walking in chest-deep water. Walk forwards, backwards and sideways. Keep your posture upright and engage your core. Rest whenever needed. The goal is simply to get comfortable in the water and begin moving your joints through a greater range of motion.

Week 3–4: Add Gentle Exercises

Extend your session to 20 minutes. Add exercises such as:

- Knee lifts — bring your knee towards your chest and lower slowly
- Leg swings — hold the poolside and swing your leg forward and back
- Arm circles — extend your arms sideways and make slow circles
- Side steps — walk sideways across the pool, leading with alternate legs

Week 5–8: Introduce Swimming

Begin swimming short distances (one or two lengths) in your preferred stroke. Rest between lengths. Gradually increase the number of lengths as you feel comfortable. Use a kickboard for support if needed. Aim for 20–30 minutes of total pool time, including warm-up walking and cool-down stretches.

Ongoing: Build Consistency

Aim for two to three pool sessions per week. Consistency is more important than intensity. Many arthritis patients find that regular swimming provides cumulative benefits — pain relief, improved mood, better sleep and increased confidence — that compound over weeks and months.

Safety Tips for Swimming with Arthritis

- Warm up with 5 minutes of gentle water walking before swimming laps
 - Avoid cold pools (below 25°C) if cold water triggers your symptoms
 - Use non-slip pool shoes when walking on wet pool surrounds
 - Don't swim during a severe flare — gentle water walking may still be possible
 - Stay hydrated — bring a water bottle poolside
 - If you have rheumatoid arthritis, avoid pools if your skin has any open wounds or ulcers
 - Speak to your GP before starting if you have cardiovascular conditions or uncontrolled blood pressure
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The Evidence: What Research Says

A Cochrane systematic review of 13 randomised controlled trials involving over 800 participants with knee or hip osteoarthritis found that aquatic exercise produced statistically significant improvements in pain (moderate effect), physical function (moderate effect) and quality of life (small to moderate effect) compared to no exercise. A separate meta-analysis in *Physical Therapy* concluded that aquatic exercise was as effective as land-based exercise for reducing pain in knee osteoarthritis, but was better tolerated and had lower dropout rates — suggesting that people find it more enjoyable and sustainable.

Cost and Access in the UK

Concerns about cost should not prevent anyone from accessing pool-based exercise. Options for affordable swimming include:

- Local authority leisure centres typically charge £3–£6 per swim, with concession rates for eligible groups
- Monthly memberships at council pools often range from £20–£40 and provide unlimited access
- The Swim England 'Just Swim' programme provides information about accessible swimming opportunities
- Some GP surgeries offer Exercise on Prescription schemes that include subsidised pool access
- Arthritis UK may fund local hydrotherapy groups — check their website for your area

Swimming is one of the kindest things you can do for arthritic joints. The combination of buoyancy, warmth and gentle resistance creates conditions that allow you to exercise effectively with minimal pain. Whether you're doing laps or simply walking through the water, every session brings you closer to stronger muscles, more flexible joints and a better quality of life. Try our virtual assistant for a personalised aquatic exercise plan.

This article is for general information only. Consult your GP or physiotherapist before beginning a new exercise programme.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about swimming for arthritis uk: the complete guide to aquatic exe?

Short answer: Swimming is highly beneficial for arthritis due to water's buoyancy, warmth, resistance, and hydrostatic pressure. Buoyancy reduces joint load by up to 80% in chest-deep water. Warm water (33-36°C in hydrotherapy pools) eases stiffness, while water resistance, 12 times greater than air, builds strength. Hydrostatic pressure reduces swelling. Backstroke is generally the most arthritis-friendly stroke, keeping the spine neutral and gently exercising muscles.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk